Code of Conduct (Verhaltenskodex)

Version 1.2 | 26 October 2026

1. Status and Scope

The Board adopts this Code of Conduct (Verhaltenskodex) under § 4 Abs. 9 of the bylaws (Satzung). It binds all members. In this Code, "the Board" means the Vorstand within the meaning of § 8 of the bylaws.

The General Assembly may amend or repeal this Code of Conduct at any time by a simple majority of the valid votes cast.

Applicants accept this Code on application for membership, which is made in text form (Textform, § 126b BGB). Members admitted before it entered into force confirmed it once in text form.

The bylaws rank above this Code. Where the two conflict, the bylaws govern and the conflicting provision of this Code is without effect. This Code creates no ground for suspension or expulsion beyond those in the bylaws.

This Code applies to conduct in the association's organs, working groups, regional representations, events, platforms and communication channels, and to conduct elsewhere where it directly affects the association. The association's channels are those operated by the Board or designated by it as such; groups and accounts run by members are not association channels.

Persons who are not members and who take part in an event or programme are bound by the terms of participation for that event or programme.

This Code is written in English. The bylaws are in German and are the binding constitutional document of the association; any German version of this Code is a translation for information.

2. Conduct

Interaction in the association is professional, factual and respectful.

Hate speech, discrimination, defamation and anti-democratic conduct are prohibited under § 3 Abs. 3 of the bylaws. That prohibition applies without exception.

Also prohibited: harassment, bullying, threats, sexual harassment and other sexual misconduct, publication of another person's personal data without authorisation, and the knowing dissemination of untrue statements of fact about the association or its members.

Substantive disagreement is a normal part of the association's work. It is conducted without personal attack.

Particular care is required in dealings with students, prospective students and young participants. Contact in connection with the association's programmes is initiated through the association's channels; individual contact outside them is limited to what the programme requires.

3. Neutrality and the Association's Name

The association's channels, platforms, events and infrastructure exist for its charitable purposes (Satzungszwecke).

Prohibited on the association's channels and at its events:

- campaigning for a political party, election advertising, and the collection of signatures for a party or candidate;
- recruitment to a religion or belief system;
- content that is unlawful, or that is abusive, discriminatory or defamatory;
- promotion of, or recruitment for, an organisation listed as an extremist organisation in the most recently published federal report on the protection of the constitution (Verfassungsschutzbericht des Bundes), and use of its symbols or gestures.

Members may treat politically relevant subjects scientifically or culturally within the charitable purposes, provided this is professional, factual and balanced. Where an exchange on the association's channels ceases to serve those purposes, the Board may close it. Closing a discussion is not a measure against any member.

No member speaks for the association without authorisation by the Board. No member uses the association's name, logo or channels in a manner suggesting that the association holds a position it has not taken. A member writing in a personal capacity says so.

Members are free to hold and express any lawful political opinion in their own name. The association neither monitors nor enquires into this; the grounds for refusing admission and for expulsion under § 4 Abs. 4 and 6 of the bylaws remain unaffected.

How the association itself speaks publicly, and how any exception is decided, is governed by the Communication Strategy.

4. Use of the Network and of Member Data

The association's network exists for its charitable purposes.

Prohibited: advertising a private business, undisclosed client acquisition, sales approaches, the sale of products or services, business development presented as networking, and recruitment for the purposes of third parties. Recruitment is permitted within a careers or recruitment format approved and announced in advance by the Board.

The association's charitable status (Gemeinnützigkeit) requires that its funds and infrastructure serve only its charitable purposes (§ 55 AO). Members do not use the association's infrastructure for business development, for the promotion of individual companies, or for the introduction of investor contacts.

Data concerning members, applicants and participants may be used only for the association's purposes. Prohibited: transfer to private undertakings, use for client acquisition, sales, recruitment or political advertising, and systematic extraction of the association's directories and platforms.

A member who uses such data for their own purposes thereby becomes a controller within the meaning of Art. 4 Nr. 7 DSGVO and is personally responsible for compliance.

Contact details obtained through the association are used for association matters unless the person concerned agrees otherwise.

Documents received in a mentoring or comparable programme are not passed on, reproduced outside the programme, or used for the recipient's own professional purposes.

5. Confidentiality

Confidential: unpublished material of the Board and of committees; personal data of members, applicants and participants; applications for scholarships, prizes and programme places; and proceedings concerning a breach of this Code. The duty of confidentiality continues after membership ends.

Confidential material is not circulated in or discussed in group chats.

Confidentiality does not restrict a member's rights to information under the bylaws or by law, a complaint to a data protection supervisory authority under Art. 77 DSGVO, a report to the tax or law enforcement authorities, or recourse to the courts.

6. Academic Integrity

Members observe academic integrity (wissenschaftliche Redlichkeit) in work for the association and in material submitted to it.

Plagiarism, falsification of evidence and knowingly or recklessly false or knowingly incomplete statements in applications for scholarships, prizes or programme places are serious breaches.

The consequences for an award obtained in this way follow the award agreement and the published award guidelines (Vergaberichtlinien).

7. Reporting

A member who becomes aware of a breach of this Code, or of facts that may constitute a ground for refusing admission or for expulsion under § 4 Abs. 4 and 6 of the bylaws, may inform the Board in text form. A member who becomes aware of a matter that may endanger the association's charitable status informs the Board in text form without delay.

A report made in good faith is not used to the disadvantage of the person making it, including where it proves unfounded. Anonymous reports are pursued only where they are sufficiently specific and supported by objective indications.

8. Measures

Measures are proportionate to the breach. They need not be applied in sequence: a serious breach may be met directly with suspension or a motion for expulsion. The measures listed here are exhaustive.

Informal notice or clarifying conversation — by a working-group head, a regional head or a member of the Board, where the breach is minor or first-time.

Written warning (Abmahnung) — by resolution of the Board, reasoned, in text form.

Removal of content — the Chair, or an administrator designated by the Board, may remove content from the association's channels that breaches this Code or the law, with immediate effect. The Board confirms the removal within two weeks. This concerns the content, not the member's access.

Suspension — under § 4 Abs. 7 of the bylaws, by reasoned resolution of the Board. Withdrawal of access to an association platform, or of the right to post on it, constitutes a suspension and may be imposed only in that form.

Expulsion — by the General Assembly on the grounds set out in § 4 Abs. 6 of the bylaws. The Board prepares the motion.

Measures under this Code do not affect civil or criminal liability.

9. Procedure

Before a written warning, a suspension or a motion for expulsion, the member is informed of the facts in text form and given at least two weeks to respond. Where a suspension is urgent, the Board may set a shorter period, which is not less than 48 hours; the member is always heard before the decision, and the suspension is limited to what the urgency requires.

Where the Board files a motion for expulsion, the period for comment is governed by § 4 Abs. 7 of the bylaws and is measured against the date of the General Assembly, not the date of notification. The Board fixes the date of notification and the date of the General Assembly so that this period is met.

A written warning and a suspension are reasoned, dated and communicated to the member in text form. The reasons state the facts relied on, the provision breached, and the considerations of proportionality. For expulsion, § 4 Abs. 7 of the bylaws applies.

The Board decides these matters in closed session. A board member concerned in the matter does not participate in the decision.

A breach is not pursued where more than twelve months have elapsed since the Board became aware of it, unless it is continuing or proceedings are already under way.

A separate, access-restricted file is kept. Access is available only to members of the Board, to the auditors (Kassenprüfer, § 9 Abs. 4 of the bylaws) and, in a conciliation to which the member concerned is a party, to the conciliator.

Recourse to the ordinary courts is not affected.

10. Entry into Force, Review and Amendment

This Code enters into force on 28 September 2026 by resolution of the Board.

This Code and any amendment are communicated to members in text form and reported to the next General Assembly. The General Assembly may amend or repeal it at any time by a simple majority of the valid votes cast. An amendment takes effect when it has been communicated to members in text form (§ 4 Abs. 8 of the bylaws), or on a later date stated in it.

Amendments have no retroactive effect. Proceedings already under way are governed by the version in force when they began, unless the later version is more favourable to the member concerned.

The Board reviews this Code annually.